anything, and therefore cannot make any decisions or create any ideas on their own.

This objection assumes that making decisions and creating ideas are predicated on having consciousness. Yet this is a fundamental misunderstanding that results from a much more widespread confusion between intelligence and consciousness. I have discussed this subject in previous books, but a short recap is unavoidable. People often confuse intelligence with consciousness, and many consequently jump to the conclusion that non-conscious entities cannot be intelligent. But intelligence and consciousness are very different. Intelligence is the ability to attain goals, such as maximising user engagement on a social media platform. Consciousness is the ability to experience subjective feelings like pain, pleasure, love and hate. In humans and other mammals, intelligence often goes hand in hand with consciousness. Facebook executives and engineers rely on their feelings in order to make decisions, solve problems and attain their goals.

But it is wrong to extrapolate from humans and mammals to all possible entities. Bacteria and plants apparently lack any consciousness, yet they too display intelligence. They gather information from their environment, make complex choices and pursue ingenious strategies to obtain food, reproduce, cooperate with other organisms and evade predators and parasites.[23] Even humans make intelligent decisions without any awareness of them; 99 per cent of the processes in our body, from respiration to digestion, happen without any conscious decision-making. Our brains decide to produce more adrenaline or dopamine, and while we may be aware of the result of that decision, we do not make it consciously.[24] The Rohingya example indicates that the same is true of computers. While computers don't feel pain, love or fear they are capable of making decisions that successfully maximise user engagement and might also affect major historical events.

Of course, as computers become more intelligent, they might eventually develop consciousness and have some kind of subjective experiences. Then again, they might become far more intelligent than us, but never develop any kind of feelings. Since we don't understand how consciousness emerges in carbon-based life-forms, we cannot foretell whether it could emerge in non-organic entities. Perhaps consciousness has no essential link to organic biochemistry, in which case conscious computers might be just around the corner. Or perhaps there are several alternative paths leading to